It was the turning point in the war. The day had been a catastrophe. Of the 1,100 men who marched out with Shelton in the morning, well over 300 had been killed, while the wounded who had been left outside were disembowelled as their wives and children looked on helplessly at the bottom of the hill. Many more who had been cut off and failed to make it back within the cantonment walls were hunted down that night. ‘Those who had survived the battle and fled back towards the English base but lost their way and tried to hide out in byways and crannies were rounded up one by one and executed,’ wrote Fayz Mohammad. ‘For the English, the calamities of this day took away whatever control they might have had over events and they were rendered virtually helpless.’[83]

Certainly, after this, the British made no more attempts at taking the initiative. ‘Shelton’s incapacity neutralised the heroism of the officers,’ wrote Mackenzie. ‘Their spirit was gone and discipline had almost disappeared.’[84] ‘Even such of the officers as had hitherto indulged in the hope of a favourable turn of events began to entertain gloomy forebodings as to our future fate,’ agreed Eyre in his diary that evening. ‘Our force resembled a ship in danger of wrecking among rocks and shoals, for want of an able pilot to guide it safely through them. Even now, at the eleventh hour, had the helm of affairs been grasped by a competent hand, we might perhaps have steered clear of destruction; but in the absence of any such deliverer, it was but too evident that Heaven alone could save us.’[85]

Instead, that night, worse news still arrived in the cantonment. Welcoming volleys from the city announced the arrival of Akbar Khan, Dost Mohammad’s most fiery and militarily effective son. He had just marched in from Bamiyan at the head of 6,000 of the Mir Wali’s Uzbek cavalry, and immediately put himself in charge of the resistance.

Akbar Khan spent the first few days after his return receiving the adulation of his people. ‘It was as if spring had brought life to a garden,’ wrote Maulana Kashmiri.

> All the nobles and chiefs came forward to pay homage
> Men and women, young and old, came out to bless him
>
> They said to him: ‘O Protector of us all!
> Our Defender, Refuge and Bedrock!’